

67 Joab

David's fierce and loyal general, who won his battles and settled his scores with the sword.

Joab was David's nephew and commander of his army for most of his reign. He was brave, shrewd and fiercely loyal to David's kingdom. He captured Jerusalem's stronghold, led Israel against the Ammonites and Syrians, and told David hard truths. But Joab also did as he pleased. He murdered two rival commanders, Abner and Amasa, arranged Uriah's death at David's order, and killed Absalom against David's command. In the end he backed the wrong son for the throne, and Solomon had him executed. Joab shows that usefulness is not the same as obedience to God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew Yo'av, usually explained as "the LORD is father"
Family	Son of Zeruah, David's sister; brothers Abishai and Asahel (1 Chronicles 2:16)
Role	Commander of David's army (2 Samuel 8:16)
When	David's reign, c. 1010–970 BC; killed c. 970 BC
Key places	Gibeon, Hebron, Jerusalem, Rabbah, Abel of Beth-maachah
Key people	David, Abner, Uriah, Absalom, Amasa, Adonijah, Solomon
New Testament	Not named

"Be of good courage, and let us play the men for our people, and for the cities of our God: and the LORD do that which seemeth him good."

2 Samuel 10:12, KJV

The life of Joab

Dates are approximate (BC). Joab served through David's whole reign, c. 1010–970 BC, and was killed early in Solomon's reign.

c. 1010 BC <i>David at Hebron</i>	● Battle at Gibeon Joab leads David's men against Abner and Saul's forces at the pool of Gibeon. His swift brother Asahel chases Abner, and Abner kills him. <i>2 Samuel 2:12–32</i>
David at Hebron	● Murders Abner Abner comes to make peace with David. Joab calls him aside in the gate of Hebron and kills him to avenge Asahel. David mourns Abner publicly. <i>2 Samuel 3:22–39</i>
c. 1003 BC	● First up at Jerusalem David promises that whoever first strikes the Jebusites will be chief. Joab goes up first and becomes commander of the army. <i>1 Chronicles 11:4–6; 2 Samuel 8:16</i>
Ammonite wars	● Rabbah and Uriah Joab besieges Rabbah. At David's written order, he sets Uriah where the fighting is fiercest, and Uriah is killed. Then he calls David to come and take the city. <i>2 Samuel 11:1–25; 12:26–29</i>
Absalom's revolt	● Kills Absalom Joab arranges Absalom's return from exile. Later, when Absalom rebels and is caught in an oak, Joab kills him despite David's order to deal gently with him. <i>2 Samuel 14:1–33; 18:1–17</i>
After the revolt	● Kills Amasa David makes Amasa commander in Joab's place. Joab greets Amasa as a brother and stabs him, then ends Sheba's revolt at Abel. <i>2 Samuel 19:13; 20:4–22</i>
c. 970 BC	● Backs Adonijah and dies Joab supports Adonijah's bid for the throne. When Solomon is crowned, Joab flees to the altar, and Benaiah kills him there at Solomon's command. <i>1 Kings 1:7; 2:28–34</i>

Key activities

David's last charge to Solomon about Joab named the killings of Abner and Amasa: he "shed the blood of war in peace" (1 Kings 2:5-6). Joab's victories in battle could not cover what he did in peacetime.

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- 1 **Took Jerusalem's stronghold.** He led the attack on the Jebusites and became chief. *1 Chronicles 11:6*
 - 2 **Avenged his brother.** He killed Abner "for the blood of Asahel his brother," leaving David to say, "these men the sons of Zeruiah be too hard for me." *2 Samuel 3:27, 39*
 - 3 **Fought with faith and courage.** Facing Ammonites and Syrians on two sides, he divided the army with Abishai and trusted the outcome to the LORD. *2 Samuel 10:9-14*
 - 4 **Carried out David's evil order.** He placed Uriah in the hottest battle and let him die. *2 Samuel 11:14-17*
 - 5 **Worked to bring Absalom home.** He sent a wise woman from Tekoa to persuade David with a story. *2 Samuel 14:1-23*
 - 6 **Killed the king's son.** He thrust three darts into Absalom as he hung in the oak. *2 Samuel 18:9-15*
 - 7 **Rebuked a grieving king.** He told David his mourning was shaming the men who had saved his life. *2 Samuel 19:1-8*
 - 8 **Warned against the census.** He asked why David wanted to number the people, but David overruled him. *2 Samuel 24:1-4*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joab.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 2-24	Joab's career under David
1 Kings 1:7; 2:5-6, 28-35	Backs Adonijah; executed by Solomon's command
1 Kings 11:15-16	Six months in Edom, cutting off every male
1 Chronicles 11:6; 19:8-15; 21:2-6	Jerusalem, his wars, the census
Echo: Proverbs 16:32	Ruling one's spirit is better than taking a city

New Testament

Echo: Matthew 26:52	"All they that take the sword shall perish with the sword"
Echo: James 1:20	"The wrath of man worketh not the righteousness of God"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* List the men Joab killed with his own hand (2 Samuel 3:27; 18:14; 20:10). What reason lay behind each?
2. *Understand:* Joab was loyal to David's kingdom but often disobeyed David. What is the difference between being useful and being faithful?
3. *Apply:* Joab carried out an order he knew was wrong. Where might you be asked to go along with something wrong at work or at home?
4. *Apply:* Joab settled his grudges himself. What grudge do you need to hand over to God this week?